Scam & Fraud Protection Guide for Seniors and Their Families

Plain-language help to spot scams, stop them, and know what to do next

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A note before you start

Scams are not a sign that someone is careless or "too old." Scammers are professionals. They practice their scripts. They use fear, love, and urgency to make smart people act fast. Today they can even use computer tools to copy a loved one's voice.

The good news: almost every scam has the same weak spot. **It falls apart the moment you slow down and check.**

This guide shows you how. Keep it near the phone. Share it with your family.

— Eric Bell, Founder and CEO, Sino Technology Solutions

How this guide is organized:

1. The most common scams, and their red flags
2. The "Stop, Hang Up, Verify" rule card (tear it out or print it)
3. Simple safety steps for your phone and computer
4. A conversation guide for families and caregivers
5. What to do if you've been scammed, step by step
6. Who to call: a resources directory

Part 1: The Most Common Scams and Their Red Flags

1. Government impostors (IRS, Social Security, Medicare)

How it works: Someone calls, texts, emails, or mails a letter saying they're from the IRS, Social Security, Medicare, or the police. They say there's a problem: you owe taxes, your Social Security number is "suspended," your benefits will stop, or you'll be arrested. They may even "transfer" you to a fake agent.

Red flags:

- They threaten arrest, legal action, or seizing your bank account.
- They say you must pay *right now*, by gift card, wire transfer, cryptocurrency, gold, or cash.
- They tell you to move your money to a "safe" or "protected" account.
- They tell you to keep it secret.
- They send a photo of a badge or ID "as proof."

What's true: Social Security says scammers pretend to be from an agency you know, say there's a problem or a prize, pressure you to act right away, and tell you to pay in a specific way. The IRS says it generally mails you a bill first, and does not call to demand immediate payment by gift card, prepaid debit card, or

wire transfer. Medicare says it will never call you to sell you anything or visit you at your home.

2. Tech-support scams

How it works: A pop-up suddenly fills your screen saying your computer is infected, often with a loud alarm and a phone number to call. Or someone calls claiming to be from a well-known company. They ask to "remote in" to your computer, pretend to find a virus, and charge you to fix it. Some go further and say your accounts were hacked and pass you to a fake "government agent."

Red flags:

- A warning on your screen tells you to call a phone number.
- Someone you didn't contact calls about a problem with your computer.
- They ask you to let them control your computer.
- They ask for payment by gift card, wire, crypto, or a payment app.
- An email says you were charged for a "subscription renewal" and must call within 24 hours.

What's true: The FTC says legitimate tech companies won't contact you by phone, email, or text to tell you there's a problem with your computer, and real security warnings never ask you to call a phone number.

3. Grandparent and family-emergency scams (including AI voice cloning)

How it works: You get a frantic call. "Grandma, it's me. I'm in trouble. I was in an accident / I'm in jail. Please don't tell Mom." Then a "lawyer" or "officer" gets on the line and asks for bail money, often in cash someone will come pick up, or by gift cards or wire.

Today the voice may sound *exactly* like your grandchild. The FBI warns that criminals use AI to make short audio clips of a loved one's voice, pretending to be a relative in a crisis and asking for money right away.

Red flags:

- A loved one is in trouble and needs money *immediately*.
- They beg you not to tell anyone else in the family.
- Someone offers to send a courier to your home to collect cash.
- The voice sounds right, but the story can't be checked.

What to do: Hang up. Call your loved one, or another family member, at the number you already have. Ask for your **family code word** (see Part 4).

4. Romance scams

How it works: Someone friendly and attentive contacts you online, on social media, or a dating site. Over weeks or months they build trust and affection. They always have a reason they

can't meet or video chat. Eventually there's an emergency, a travel problem, a medical bill, or an "investment opportunity," and they need money.

Red flags:

- They profess strong feelings very quickly.
- They can never meet in person, or always cancel at the last minute.
- They ask for money, gift cards, or crypto, or ask you to receive and forward money for them.
- They steer you toward an investment they're "sure" about.

What's true: The FBI warns that criminals use AI to make fake profile photos and even videos to "prove" they're a real person.

5. Lottery, sweepstakes, and prize scams

How it works: "Congratulations, you've won!" There's just one catch: you have to pay taxes, fees, or shipping first.

Red flags:

- You "won" a contest you never entered.
- You must pay to collect a prize.
- They ask for your bank account number to "deposit your winnings."

Remember: A real prize never costs you money to collect.

6. Investment and cryptocurrency scams

How it works: Someone, often a new online friend or someone who "found you" through a wrong-number text, offers to help you invest. They show you a website or app where your money seems to grow fast. When you try to withdraw it, there are "fees" or "taxes" first, and the money never comes out.

Red flags:

- Guaranteed high returns with "no risk."
- Pressure to invest quickly before the "opportunity" closes.
- You're told to buy cryptocurrency, or deposit cash into a crypto ATM.
- You can't withdraw your money without paying more.

7. Payment demands: gift cards, wire transfers, crypto ATMs, gold, and cash

This isn't a separate scam. It's how almost *every* scam gets paid.

The rule: If anyone asks you to pay with **gift cards, a wire transfer, cryptocurrency, a crypto ATM, gold bars, or cash handed to a courier**, it is a scam. Every time.

Social Security says scammers insist on these payment methods because they are hard to trace. The FTC says that once you pay this way, it's very hard to get your money back.

Store clerk tip: If a store clerk asks, "Is someone telling you to buy these gift cards?", please tell them the truth. They are trying

to help you.

8. Home-repair and contractor scams

How it works: Someone knocks on your door saying they noticed a problem with your roof, driveway, or trees, often after a storm. They offer a great deal, want payment up front, and either do poor work or disappear.

Red flags:

- Unsolicited, door-to-door offers, "We were just in the neighborhood."
- Pressure to decide today.
- A large payment up front, especially in cash.
- No written contract, license, or local address.

What to do: Never hire on the spot. Get written estimates from local companies you looked up yourself. Ask a family member or trusted neighbor before you sign.

9. Phishing texts and emails

How it works: A message looks like it's from your bank, Amazon, the post office, a toll company, or a store. It says there's a problem with your account, a package, or a refund, and gives you a link to click. The link leads to a fake website that steals your password or card number.

AARP's Fraud Watch Network Helpline currently warns about fake "recall" messages that claim something you bought was recalled

and ask you to sign in through a link. They often pretend to be companies like Amazon, Costco, and Walmart.

Red flags:

- A message you weren't expecting, with a link or attachment.
- Urgency: "Your account will be closed," "Final notice."
- It asks you to "confirm" your password, card, or Social Security number.

What to do: Don't click the link. Go to the company's official website or app yourself, or call the number on the back of your card.

Part 2: The "Stop, Hang Up, Verify" Rule Card

Cut out this page and keep it by your phone.

STOP.

If you feel scared, rushed, or excited, that's the scam working.

Take a breath. Nothing real needs your money in the next five minutes.

HANG UP.

You are always allowed to hang up, close the email, or shut the door.

It's not rude. It's smart.

VERIFY.

Call back using a number YOU already know: the one on the back of your card, on your statement, or in your own phone contacts. Never use the number they gave you.

Call a family member and say the code word.

NEVER, EVER:

- Pay with **gift cards, wire transfers, crypto, a crypto ATM, gold, or cash to a courier**
- Let a stranger **control your computer**
- Give your **Social Security, Medicare, or bank numbers** to someone who called *you*
- **Keep it a secret** because a caller told you to

My family code word is: _____

My trusted person to call: _____

Phone: _____

National Elder Fraud Hotline: 1-833-372-8311 (Monday–Friday, 10 a.m.–6 p.m. Eastern)

Part 3: Simple Safety Steps for Your Phone and Computer

On your phone

1. **Let unknown calls go to voicemail.** A real caller will leave a message. You can call back using a number you look up yourself.
2. **Turn on your phone's call-blocking or spam-labeling feature.** Your phone company can help you set it up.
3. **Register on the National Do Not Call Registry** at DoNotCall.gov or by calling 1-888-382-1222 from the phone you want to register. It's free. The FTC notes that it stops sales calls from legitimate companies, but it won't stop scammers, so keep hanging up on them.
4. **Don't press buttons** on a robocall to "be removed from the list." The FTC says to just hang up.
5. **Set a screen lock** (a passcode, fingerprint, or face) on your phone.
6. **Don't click links in texts** you weren't expecting.

On your computer and tablet

1. **Turn on automatic updates** for your computer, phone, tablet, and web browser. Updates fix security holes.
2. **Use security software** and keep it up to date.

3. **Never call a number from a pop-up.** Close the browser. If it won't close, turn the computer off and back on.
4. **Never let someone you don't know "remote in"** to your computer.
5. **Use a different, strong password for each important account**, especially email and banking. A password manager, or a written password book kept somewhere safe at home, can help.
6. **Turn on two-step verification** (a code sent to your phone or an app) for email, banking, and Social Security accounts.
7. **Create your own "my Social Security" account at ssa.gov/myaccount.** Social Security says this helps stop identity thieves from opening one in your name, and alerts you if someone tries to change your address or direct deposit.
8. **Check your bank and credit card statements** every month. Look for anything you don't recognize.
9. **Check your Medicare statements.** Medicare recommends comparing the dates and services with your own calendar.
10. **Consider freezing your credit** at all three credit bureaus (Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion). It's free and helps prevent new accounts from being opened in your name. You can lift it any time you need to apply for credit.

Part 4: A Conversation Guide for Families and Caregivers

For adult children, grandchildren, and anyone who helps care for an older adult.

Start the conversation the right way

- **Talk early, before anything happens.** It's much easier to talk about scams in general than after a loss.
- **Make it about everyone.** "These scams are getting so good, even I almost fell for one." Scammers target all ages.
- **No blame, no shame.** If your loved one is embarrassed, they may hide the next scam from you. Make it safe to tell you anything.
- **Share real stories** from the news or from this guide, not lectures.

Set up a family code word

The FBI recommends creating a secret word or phrase with your family to verify identity, because criminals can now clone a loved one's voice.

1. Pick a word or short phrase that's easy to remember but **not** posted anywhere online. Not a pet's name, street, or school.
2. Share it **in person or on a call you started**, never by text or email.

3. Agree on the rule: **"If someone calls in an emergency asking for money, I'll ask for the code word. No word, no money."**
4. Write it on the rule card in Part 2 and keep it by the phone.
5. Practice once. It makes it feel normal.

Questions to ask together

- "Has anyone called, texted, or emailed you lately asking for money or personal information?"
- "Do you know what you'd do if someone said I was in jail and needed bail?"
- "Has anyone asked you to buy gift cards or use a crypto ATM?"
- "Have you met anyone new online recently?"
- "Who would you call if something felt wrong?"

Practical steps you can take together

- **Put trusted numbers in their phone**: you, other family, their bank, and their doctor.
- **Turn on call blocking** on their phone and register their number on the Do Not Call Registry.
- **Help set up bank alerts** for large withdrawals or transfers. Ask their bank whether they offer a "trusted contact" option.
- **Help freeze their credit** at Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion.
- **Check that their devices update automatically** and have security software.

- **Help them set up two-step verification** on email and banking.

Warning signs that someone may be targeted

- Secretive phone calls, or new "friends" they won't talk about
- Unusual withdrawals, wire transfers, or gift card purchases
- Seeming anxious, fearful, or ashamed about money
- New, unfamiliar people "helping" with finances
- Remote-access software they don't remember installing

If you suspect an older adult is being exploited, you can contact your state's **Adult Protective Services** (see the directory in Part 6).

Part 5: What to Do If You've Been Scammed

First: it is not your fault. Social Security says it plainly: "Criminal behavior is not your fault." Act quickly, and don't let embarrassment slow you down.

Step 1: Stop all contact

Stop talking to the scammer. Block their phone number, email, or profile. Don't send any more money, even if they promise to return what you lost.

Beware of "recovery" scams. The FBI's IC3 says it does not work with non-law-enforcement groups, like law firms or crypto services, to recover lost funds, and will never contact you directly for information or money.

Step 2: Call the company you used to pay, right away

Based on the FTC's guidance:

- **Bank transfer or Zelle:** call your bank or credit union. Ask them to reverse the payment.
- **Credit or debit card:** call the number on the back of your card. Ask for a refund.
- **Payment app (Venmo, Cash App, PayPal):** report it in the app and ask for a reversal.

- **Wire transfer (Western Union, MoneyGram):** call the company, tell them a scammer tricked you, and ask for a refund.
- **Gift card:** call the number on the back of the card. Keep the card and the receipt.
- **Cryptocurrency or crypto ATM:** contact the exchange or ATM operator. Tell them it was fraud and ask them to reverse it.
- **Cash sent by U.S. mail:** call the U.S. Postal Inspection Service at 1-877-876-2455 immediately.

Step 3: Secure your accounts and identity

- **Gave out a password?** Change it right away, and anywhere else you used it. Turn on two-step verification.
- **Let someone into your computer?** Update your security software, run a scan, and change your passwords.
- **Gave out your Social Security number?** Go to IdentityTheft.gov for a recovery plan. Consider freezing your credit at all three bureaus.

Step 4: Report it

Reporting helps stop scammers and protect others.

- **FTC:** ReportFraud.ftc.gov
- **FBI:** ic3.gov (for online and cyber-enabled fraud)
- **Local police:** Social Security recommends calling your local police department to report the crime.

- **Age 60 or older?** Call the National Elder Fraud Hotline at 1-833-372-8311. A case manager will help you report at the federal, state, and local levels.

Step 5: Write everything down

Keep a record of names, phone numbers, emails, websites, dates, amounts, how you paid, and receipts. The FBI's IC3 asks for details like these when you file.

Step 6: Talk to someone

Being scammed is upsetting. Call a trusted family member or friend, or the **AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline at 1-877-908-3360** for support and guidance.

Part 6: Resources Directory

Every contact below was checked on its official website on October 16, 2026. Phone numbers and hours can change, so if a number doesn't work, look it up on the official website.

Get help and report fraud

National Elder Fraud Hotline (U.S. Department of Justice) Phone: 1-833-FRAUD-11 (1-833-372-8311) Hours: Monday–Friday, 10 a.m.–6 p.m. Eastern. English, Spanish, and other languages. For fraud against anyone age 60 or older. Website: ovc.ojp.gov/program/stop-elder-fraud *Note: the Hotline warns that scammers are pretending to be Hotline staff. The real Hotline won't threaten to sue you.*

AARP Fraud Watch Network Helpline Phone: 1-877-908-3360 Hours: Monday–Friday, 8 a.m.–8 p.m. Eastern. Translation available. Help deciding if something is a scam, and support after a scam. Website: aarp.org/money/scams-fraud/helpline

Federal Trade Commission (FTC): Report fraud Website: ReportFraud.ftc.gov Phone (with interpreter help, listed by Social Security): 1-877-382-4357, press 3 for an interpreter.

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center (IC3) Website: ic3.gov For online and cyber-enabled fraud. In an emergency, call 911.

IdentityTheft.gov (FTC) Website: IdentityTheft.gov Report identity theft and get a personal recovery plan.

Government benefit scams

Social Security Office of the Inspector General Report a Social Security scam: oig.ssa.gov/report Learn about scams: ssa.gov/scam

Medicare fraud Phone: 1-800-MEDICARE (1-800-633-4227) Medicare Advantage or drug plan fraud: I-MEDIC, 1-877-7SAFERX (1-877-772-3379) Website: medicare.gov/basics/reporting-medicare-fraud-and-abuse

Local help for older adults

Eldercare Locator (U.S. Administration for Community Living) Phone or text: 1-800-677-1116 Email: eldercarelocator@usaging.org Website: eldercare.acl.gov Connects you to local services for older adults and families.

Adult Protective Services (APS) Find your state's APS number: napsa-now.org/help-in-your-area Example: Florida Adult Protective Services, 1-800-962-2873 *NAPSA itself does not investigate cases. Contact the APS office in the state where the older adult lives.*

Freeze your credit (free at all three)

Equifax Website: equifax.com/personal/credit-report-services/credit-freeze Phone: 1-888-298-0045

Experian Website: experian.com/freeze/center.html Phone: 1-888-EXPERIAN (1-888-397-3742)

TransUnion Website: transunion.com/credit-freeze Phone: 1-800-916-8800

A freeze at one bureau does not freeze the others. Contact all three.

Fewer sales calls

National Do Not Call Registry Website: DoNotCall.gov Phone: 1-888-382-1222 (TTY: 1-866-290-4236). Call from the phone you want to register. Free. Registration never expires.

Mail fraud

U.S. Postal Inspection Service (if you mailed cash to a scammer) Phone: 1-877-876-2455

Need a hand securing a loved one's devices or accounts?

Setting up call blocking, updates, two-step verification, and credit freezes isn't hard, but it can be a lot to do alone. If your family would like help securing a parent's or grandparent's phone, computer, or online accounts, **book a free 20-minute security check-in: email info@sinotechsol.com**.

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This guide offers general safety information. It is not legal or financial advice. If you are in immediate danger, call 911.